> The merchants were taking off their commodities from the shops, and the whole city appeared in commotion. Mirza Khodad, secretary to Sultan Jan [one of the leading Barakzai rebels who had been with Dost Mohammad in Bukhara], came to my house and being my old acquaintance, warned me of the danger in which I was then standing, by remaining in my house and not sending away my property. Naib Sharif [one of the Qizilbash chiefs and an old carousing companion of Burnes] also sent his father-in-law, to fetch me to the Persian Quarters, with all my valuable things. But I refused to attend to their kind advice, fearing that my stirring from the house might increase the apprehension of the impending danger. So I sent my servant with a note to Sir Alexander Burnes, whose residence was separated by a few buildings from my house, conveying to him the messages I had received . . . His reply was that I must remain in my house, and that he has sent for troops, and that they will soon be in town. Half an hour after this, my servant informed me that the Nizam al-Daula was advising that officer to quit his house and to proceed with him to the Bala Hisar, as there was very great risk to his personal safety.[7]

Burnes had been so confident of his safety and popularity that he had only twelve guards. He had just decided to leave with the Wazir when at the last minute he was persuaded to stay by his old Jamadar (the head of his bodyguard), who reminded him that he had just sent a message to Macnaghten and that he should really wait for the Envoy's reply. So Nizam al-Daula left alone, promising to return with a battalion of Shah Shuja's troops. As he rode away he was fired upon from the rooftops, but managed to fight his way back to the Bala Hisar.

At this point the rebel leaders – a mixed crew of disaffected Royalists, Barakzai sardars, angry aristocrats furious about the military reforms, unemployed former bureaucrats and middle-ranking 'ulema not in the Shah's service – arrived in Ashiqan wa Arifan, at the corner of the Shor Bazaar. Directed by Abdullah Khan Achakzai who had quickly assumed military command of the uprising, they took up positions in the garden next to Burnes's house. As Colin Mackenzie noted in his diary, the rebel leaders 'hated Burnes as the man universally believed to have guided the British into Afghanistan. They alleged he did not behave to them with proper respect. Burnes thought himself popular with the lower classes; but it is doubtful if he was so, while the chiefs regarded him as the chief agent in introducing that system of order which was utterly repugnant to them.'[8] So when Burnes sent two messengers to ask what the complaints of the rebel chiefs were, and inviting them to come to terms, the chiefs merely beheaded the first messenger, leaving the other to report this reply to Burnes. The chiefs' men were then ordered up on to the rooftops, to try and work their way into the back of Burnes's compound. He was to be offered no quarter.